

A Basic Video-conferencing Toolkit

- A PC monitor, LCD panel or desktop video-conferencing system, which is either portable or fixed, depending on the number of participants (conferences, classrooms, or presentations)
- Camera/Webcam with a video input connection. Multiple cameras may facilitate better coverage
- Microphones/speakers. A remote control could be used to control volume, and even camera settings, if required
- Codecs—Used for compressing and decompressing data, codecs can be software or hardware-based, or a combination of both. Slow codecs or low bandwidth can cause jerky images or lags in AV output.

and individual customers on rent. Clients can avail of the services at the offices of these providers or lease out hardware. Support personnel are also sent with the equipment to set up a conference call and ensure that the ISDN line is functioning.

Kiran Datar, COO, WebEx, which offers video-conferencing services across the five major metros, calls it a “one-stop shop for audio, Web, and video-conferencing solutions as well as Web casting services. It doesn’t really make sense for some companies to purchase expensive conferencing hardware. Our clients, mostly corporates, either come to our studio and avail our services, or we transport our equipment to their offices. We provide cameras, equipment and video-conferencing services via an ISDN line. We charge depending on the duration of the call, services used, etc.”

Emerging Trends

In 2001, video-conferencing aided the world’s first transatlantic tele-surgery—a surgeon in the US used a robot overseas to perform gall bladder surgery on a patient. Now, telemedicine has become a reality in several countries including ours, with hospitals such as the Apollo Group in Chennai (their telemedicine application ‘Medintegra’ helps doctors devise treatment regimes for patients in remote locations), and Wockhardt Hospital and Heart Institute, Bangalore (which enables doctors to monitor the vital parameters of patients admitted to their Intensive Cardiac Care Unit, in



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real-time, from anywhere in the world), to name a few.

On an average, the telemedicine networks in these hospitals charge between Rs 500 to Rs 600 per remote consultation. For the patient, however, telemedicine helps save on travel and lodging costs and high consultancy fees at specialised facilities. “Although Indian hospitals are showcasing video-conferencing-aided remote surgeries at exhibitions, it is yet to take off in a big way in India,” says Arun Giri, senior manager (business development), Apollo Telemedicine Networking Foundation, Hyderabad.

When US forces attacked Afghanistan, television reporters used portable satellites and videophones to broadcast war footage live. Newscasters back home could converse live—complete with video—with reporters embedded within war zones.

E-learning, another rapidly evolving trend, involves proactive use of video-conferencing for “virtual classrooms.” With increased quality of streaming video, and lesser lags or delays in transmission, interactive classrooms are now gaining popularity.

The Indian Institutes of Technology (IITs), for example, use video-conferencing to enable students in remote areas to pursue advanced courses in engineering. The courses (Embedded systems, Mobile computing, Signals and Systems are some of the subjects offered) cost anywhere between Rs 2,000 (for students/teachers) and Rs 10,000 (for working professionals). The biggest advantage of the IITs’ distance education programme is that participants from remote centres have access to academic support, and can interact with faculty—students attending the lectures can ask questions and receive answers in real-time.

With more and more organisations implementing video-conferencing solutions to reduce travel costs, network better and increase efficiency, the conventional notion of a “board meeting” may soon give way to its virtual counterpart. ■

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